CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Saturday, October 17, 2026

2,078 words · 8 min read

RE: Chalmers-Albanese rift reported · Rabuka rules out Constitution extension · Fiji presses Beijing for deliverables · Cyclone Wati off Cook Islands · Guam at COR 1

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,807	0.6949	13,754	0.5655
+1.03%	-0.52%	+0.03%	+0.71%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Labor MPs privately question whether **Jim Chalmers**' relationship with **Anthony Albanese** has soured, with caucus described as more unsettled than at any point since 2022.
2. Fiji told the sixth China-Pacific Island Countries Political Leadership Dialogue in Beijing that cooperation must be measured by improvements in ordinary people's lives rather than by agreements and declarations.
3. Tropical Cyclone Wati formed north of Suwarrow and is tracking toward the southern Cook Islands, while Guam moved to Condition of Readiness 1 as Typhoon Champi intensified toward Category 4.

TOP STORIES

AU-POLITICS

Labor insiders say economic pain has strained Chalmers-Albanese relationship

Labor MPs are questioning behind closed doors whether **Jim Chalmers**' relationship with **Anthony Albanese** has soured, the Sydney Morning Herald reports. Several Labor insiders say the caucus is more unsettled and irritable than at any point since the party took power, despite what the paper describes as a remarkable period of stability by the standards of contemporary politics in Australia and abroad. The government holds 94 of 150 House seats.

per SMH (Paul Sakkal): "In a funk: How economic pain is straining the PM and treasurer's relationship"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Rabuka rejects calls to extend Fiji Constitution consultation

Fiji Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** has ruled out extending the public consultation period on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill, despite requests from non-governmental organisations for more time during hearings in Suva and Nausori. The refusal lands as the University of Fiji's law students urge the government to abandon the bill outright, and as submitters challenge the draft's retention of immunity provisions tied to the coups of 1987, 2000, and 2006.

per PNG Post-Courier: "Fiji PM rules out extending Constitution consultation period"

CHINA-PACIFIC

Fiji tells Beijing dialogue that partnerships must deliver tangible results

Assistant Minister for Health and Medical Services **Penioni Ravunawa**, heading Fiji's delegation to the sixth China-Pacific Island Countries Political Leadership Dialogue in Beijing, said cooperation "must be measured by improvements in the lives of ordinary people" rather than by agreements and diplomatic declarations. He called for partnerships that respect Pacific priorities and national sovereignty, and sought greater cooperation on renewable energy, climate adaptation, sustainable infrastructure, ocean protection, and disaster preparedness.

per Fiji Sun: "China-Pacific partnerships must deliver tangible results"

OVERNIGHT

TRADE-ECONOMY

Greenpeace activists occupy Woodside gas project unit off Western Australia · Reuters

Greenpeace activists occupied a unit of a Woodside gas project off Western Australia, Reuters reported. The wire filing did not identify the facility or the number of activists involved, and carried no company response at the time of publication. Woodside's offshore gas developments off the Western Australian coast have been a repeated target of direct-action protest.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Guam moves to Condition of Readiness 1 as Champi intensifies · Pacific Island Times

Governor **Lourdes A. Leon Guerrero** placed Guam in Condition of Readiness 1 at 1 pm, with destructive winds forecast within 12 hours. The Joint Typhoon Warning Center tracked Champi east of Guam with sustained winds of *132 mph* and gusts to 161 mph, and said it was likely to reach Category 4. National Weather Service meteorologist **Landon Aydlett** warned of "explosive rapid intensification" and said: "This is going to be a significant strike to Guam."

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Vanuatu to table first comprehensive adoption law next week · Vanuatu Daily Post

The Adoption Bill 2026 will be tabled during next week's extraordinary session of Parliament, Minister of Justice, Youth and Community Services **Job Andy** confirmed. The legislation would be Vanuatu's first comprehensive domestic law governing formal adoption, an area that has drawn scrutiny from child-protection agencies and partner governments across Melanesia.

AU-POLITICS

Government knew for months of ATO move to end credit card payments · SMH

The federal government was aware for months that the Australian Taxation Office was considering ending credit card payments in response to the surcharge ban, the Sydney Morning Herald reports. The decision prompted an intervention by the prime minister this week after complaints from small-business groups, and has become a live test of how the surcharge reform lands in practice.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Cook Islands opposition opens interim office, pledges spending discipline · Cook Islands News

The interim Office of the Leader of the Opposition in Nikao opened on Thursday afternoon and will admit the public from Monday. The opposition leader used the opening to promise tight control over taxpayer funds, setting fiscal oversight as the office's organising theme as it begins operating with dedicated premises for the first time.

STAT OF THE DAY

$1,000

Australian chickpea price per tonne

Prices have risen from about $600 earlier this year even as national production is forecast to fall more than 50 percent.

ABC News

AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · 9DASHLINE

Forum asks whether AUKUS undercuts the Indo-Pacific order it claims to defend

9DashLine convened experts on whether AUKUS, which it calls "FOIP's most explicitly hard-security expression," sits uneasily with Pacific Island states' own security vision. The forum notes that the Blue Pacific Ocean of Peace Declaration, adopted by Pacific Islands Forum leaders in September 2025, "explicitly rejects great-power rivalry and nuclear militarisation," and asks how Pacific states are defining regional security on their own terms.

PACIFIC WIRE

COOK ISLANDS · RNZ

Aitutaki told to follow updates as Cyclone Wati approaches

Tropical Cyclone Wati formed north of Suwarrow and is tracking southeast, bringing damaging gale-force winds, heavy rain, and dangerous seas to the northern Cook Islands. Authorities urged Aitutaki residents to heed official updates as conditions deteriorate across the southern group. Fiji's weather office says the Category 1 system poses no direct threat to Fiji.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

University of Fiji counts almost 100 drafting faults in Constitution Bill

Vice-Chancellor Professor **Shaista Shameem** gave the Parliamentary Constitutional Review Special Committee a four-page list identifying *almost 100 issues* in Constitution Amendment Bill No. 32 of 2026,

including contradictory clauses, cross-referencing mistakes, and inconsistencies with the explanatory notes. She said the vacant parliamentary draftsperson position should be filled before the bill proceeds further.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

One United Republican Party lodges registration application

The proposed One United Republican Party has submitted its application for registration to the Fijian Elections Office. The filing adds to the field forming ahead of Fiji's next general election, which is being contested against the backdrop of the constitutional amendment debate.

REGIONAL · PNG POST-COURIER

Forum Secretariat and PCRIC explore financing for El Niño drought risk

The Pacific Islands Forum Secretariat and the Pacific Catastrophe Risk Insurance Company are exploring closer cooperation to help member states prepare financially for climate shocks, including drought risk linked to El Niño. The talks come as forecasters warn of elevated cyclone risk across the region this season.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Court orders Vanuatu to pay former IMO envoy about VT75 million

The Supreme Court ordered the Republic of Vanuatu to pay former Ambassador and Permanent Representative **Laurent Parente** 574,941 euros, about *VT75 million*, in employment entitlements plus interest and legal costs, after finding he had been continuously employed. The judgment adds to the government's liabilities from long-running disputes over diplomatic postings.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Cabinet appoints Su'a Aulaga Faumuina as Samoa's Regulator

Cabinet approved the appointment of **Su'a Aulaga Faumuina** as Regulator for a three-year term, the government said on Saturday. He replaces **Lematua Gisa Fuatai Purcell** and moves up from Assistant Chief Executive Officer for Spectrum Management and Technical Services, having joined the Office of the Regulator in 2014 as Principal Electricity Sector Specialist.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

First reported escape from Bomana Immigration Centre

A Sierra Leone national detained over a visa breach climbed a rear fence at the Bomana Immigration Centre in Port Moresby in the early hours of Saturday, in what the Post-Courier reports is the first escape from the facility. Bomana has featured in Australia-funded regional migration arrangements.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Brown presses public sector leaders to trim priorities

Prime Minister **Mark Brown** urged public sector leaders to collaborate across agencies, trim lingering priorities, and lift efficiency so the government can meet its core national commitments and serve all citizens equally. The call comes as the Ministry of Finance and Economic Management prepares to recommend extending Rarotonga's free bus service.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ABC PACIFIC

Temotu premier says MV Awka rescue was too slow

More than 70 passengers were saved from the MV Awka in Solomon Islands waters, but Temotu Province Premier **Stanley Tehiahua** said the operation was delayed even as it succeeded. **Basil Leodoro**, operations director of Vanuatu's emergency response ship HELPR-1, said weather conditions facing rescue crews at sea offered lessons for future operations.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

RNZ tests Luxon's claim that his government has strengthened healthcare

Prime Minister **Christopher Luxon** told colleagues in August, after surviving his second leadership challenge, that the government had "certainly strengthened healthcare." RNZ's analysis sets that against the worst flu outbreak in 10 years, overloaded emergency departments, and clinicians who say they saw no sign of the government's winter plan, with some calling for an end to Health NZ's hiring go-slow. New Zealand votes on November 7.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

FIJI · OTHER · FIJI SUN

Fiji journalists study Beijing's citizen complaints hotline

Fiji Sun reports from the 2026 Beijing Forum on Swift Response to Public Complaints, which drew more than 3,200 participants from over 70 countries under the theme "Digital Intelligence Era and People's City." Beijing's 12345 hotline has consolidated more than 60 government services since 2019 and processed over 200 million appeals, a model the paper frames as instructive for Pacific service delivery.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Senate hostility and polling leave Labor backbenchers rattled

Labor's 94-seat majority dominates the lower house, but the ABC reports that private conversations in the corridors this week produced "stories and anecdotes galore of unhappy, rattled and angry Labor MPs." The Senate's growing hostility to the government's agenda is the variable to watch at roughly the halfway mark of the parliament.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

ACCI chief says small business trust is eroding over tax changes

Australian Chamber of Commerce and Industry chief executive **Andrew McKellar** told Insiders: On Background that the ATO credit card episode, which drew a prime ministerial intervention, feeds wider business unease about the government's impending trust tax changes. He also addressed the split inside the Coalition over the European Union free trade deal.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Former Greens candidate calls internal probe of Steele-John 'on the nose'

Former Greens candidate **Megan Krakouer** has questioned the party's internal investigation into Senator **Jordon Steele-John**, calling the process "on the nose." The intervention widens a dispute that began with reporting on a dossier concerning the senator, which the Greens leader said this week he had no knowledge of.

AU-POLITICS · POLITICO

Politico: Albanese banks on 'kicking with the wind'

Politico writes up **Anthony Albanese**'s "kicking with the wind" formulation, the prime minister's wager that policy signal will eventually overcome political noise. The framing lands in the same week as reporting on caucus discontent and weak polling.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Forensic audit finds 40 years of duplication in Bureau of Meteorology data

A forensic audit has exposed widespread copy-paste errors across the Bureau of Meteorology's raw climate data spanning four decades, The Australian reports, and the bureau has admitted errors after the duplicated

historical temperature records were identified. The agency's data underpins federal climate and disaster planning.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Chickpea prices approach $1,000 a tonne as buyers lock in supply

Delivered chickpea prices have surged toward *$1,000 per tonne* in some regions, up from about $600 earlier in the year. Grains Australia Pulse Council chair **Peter Wilson** said prices had not reached that level since 2024, citing logistics volatility and El Niño-reduced monsoon rainfall in India. Australian production is forecast to fall more than 50 percent this season as buyers move ahead of Ramadan.

TRADE-ECONOMY · FIJI SUN

Fiji Airports starts 3.25MW Nadi solar farm, tightens spending

Acting chief executive **Amit Singh** told a parliamentary committee that Fiji Airports has imposed controls on transport, electricity use, and staff travel in response to fuel price volatility, while beginning work on a *3.25-megawatt* solar farm at Nadi International Airport for completion by 2029. Committee member **Ketan Lal** questioned how bidders for the project were vetted.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Jacob defends Firmus bet after float collapse

Investor **Ashok Jacob** has defended his position in Firmus following the collapse of the $4.4 billion float, saying he cannot say how the venture ends. The failure of what was billed as Australia's largest initial public offering in decades has unsettled local exposure to the artificial intelligence trade.

UPCOMING

OCT 26 — **Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election**
Early ballots begin while the government's health record is under contest.

OCT 2026 — **Vanuatu extraordinary parliamentary session, Adoption Bill 2026 tabled**
Would give Vanuatu its first comprehensive domestic law on formal adoption.

NOV 7 — **New Zealand general election**
Determines whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues its foreign and defence settings.

NOV 20 — **Vanuatu's 30-day notice to owners of abandoned vessels in Port Vila Harbour expires**
Clears the way for removals to begin in December under the Department of Ports and Harbour plan.

DEC 1 — **Trial of Efate Rural MP Luo Xiang Jian in the Supreme Court of Vanuatu**
Remaining perjury and non-compliance charges against a sitting MP return to court.

THE WIRE

AU-DEFENSE

THE AUSTRALIAN

Inside the LR5 submersible held ready for Australian submariners

The Australian goes aboard the LR5 submarine rescue vehicle, the craft crews describe as "our lifeline" if a boat is disabled at depth. Rescue capability is a standing requirement as the Royal Australian Navy plans for a larger submarine force.

TRADE-ECONOMY

REUTERS

Australia confirms first H5N1 case on sub-Antarctic Macquarie Island

Australia has confirmed its first case of H5N1 bird flu on Macquarie Island, Reuters reported, extending the virus's reach into the sub-Antarctic. The island sits within Australian jurisdiction and hosts long-running research and wildlife monitoring programmes.

AU-POLITICS

ABC NEWS

Canberra marks 25 years since the SIEV X sinking

Mourners gathered at the SIEV X Memorial on Lake Burley Griffin to mark 25 years since 353 people, including 146 children, drowned when a fishing boat bound for Christmas Island sank off Java on October 19, 2001. Forty-five survivors were rescued more than 20 hours later by Indonesian fishing boats.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FBC NEWS

Fiji elections supervisor says free rides do not bind voters

Supervisor of Elections **Ana Mataiciwa** said voters are not obliged to support a candidate or party in return for free transport or refreshments under Fiji's amended electoral laws, and must exercise an independent choice regardless of any assistance received.

FIJI SUN

Experts tell Fiji truth commission that reconciliation needs justice

At a Fiji Truth and Reconciliation Commission expert hearing in Suva on October 6, Fiji National University academic **Dr Mosmi Bhim** presented an assessment finding sustained repression and institutional decline in civil society after the 1987, 2000, and 2006 upheavals. "Without justice there can be no respect, there can be no dignity," she said.

ABC PACIFIC

Fiji justice minister resigns over circulated video

Fiji's justice minister has stepped down over a sex video circulated on social media, ABC Pacific's Pacific Review reported. The same programme noted Fiji is calling on the United States to provide evidence of corruption allegations against a Chinese-Fijian businessman.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

UNITED STATES STUDIES CENTRE · USSC

Leveraging private capital in defence: Lessons for Australia from the United States

The United States Studies Centre examines how private capital has been channelled into American defence production and what mechanisms could transfer to the Australian setting. The piece is framed as lessons for Australian policymakers rather than a critique of current settings.

> **Argument:** Australia can draw on United States practice in mobilising private capital to fund and scale defence industrial capability.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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